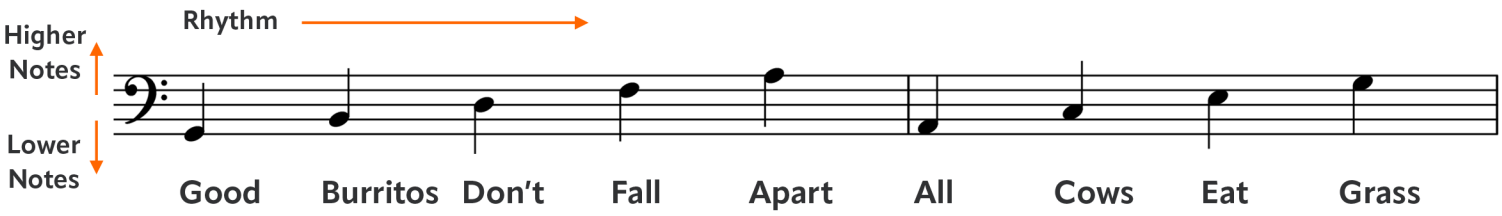
HOW TO READ MUSIC

Reference Guide

The Music Staff

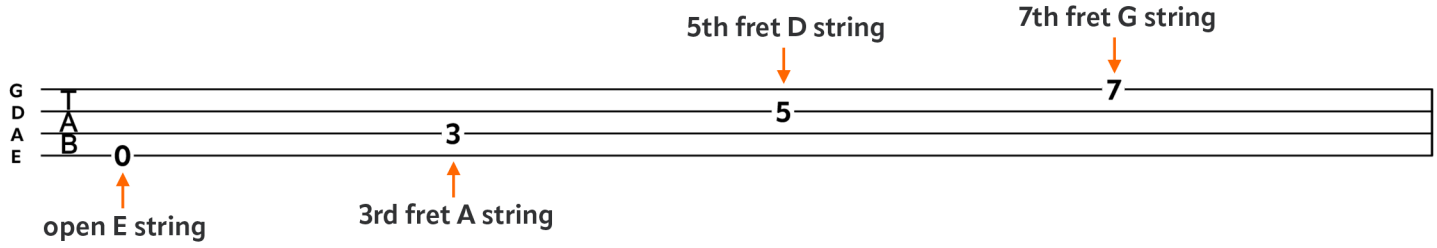
The staff shows you two things - notes and rhythm. Notes are arranged vertically on the lines and spaces. Rhythm moves along from left to right.



These mnemonics are helpful for remembering the names of the notes in the lines and spaces. And also for making good burritos.

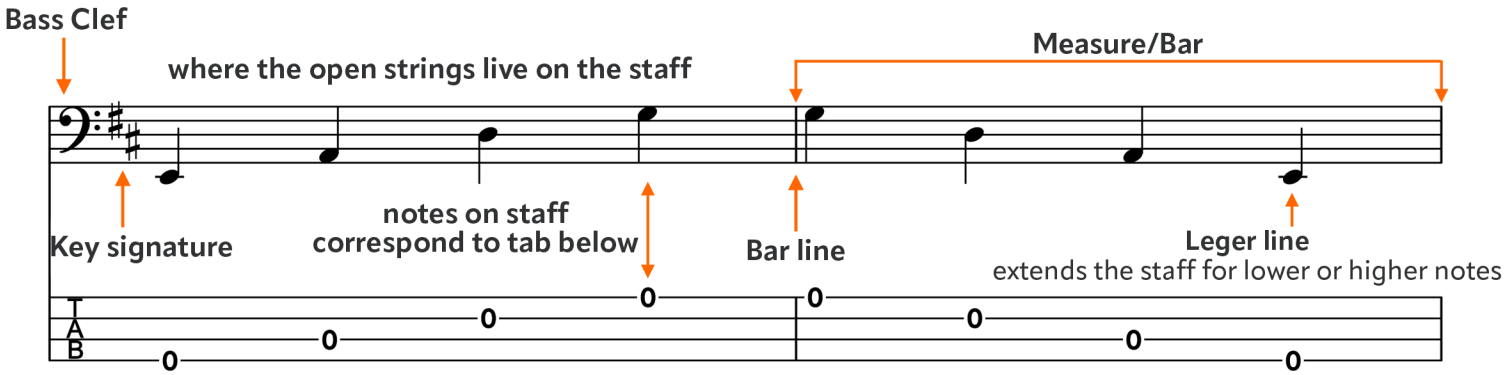
The Tab Staff

Tablature is bass-specific notation with one line for each string, and numbers that tell you what fret to play on. Note: tab doesn't have rhythm.



With Powers Combined

Reading both these staves together is killer on bass, cuz it tells you what notes to play, when to play them, AND where to put them on the bass.

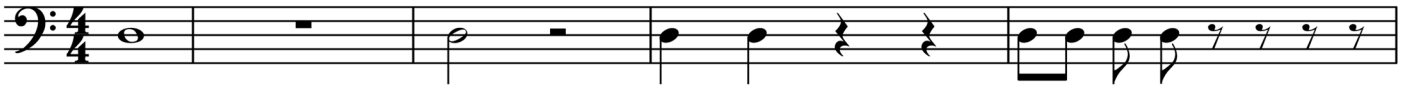


BASS BUZZ

Rhythm Notation

Time Signature

Top number: # of beats in the measure (four)
Bottom number: type of note that equals one beat (quarter note)



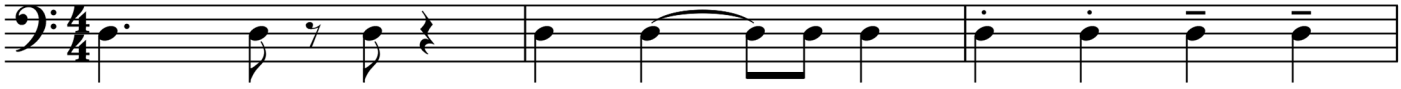
Whole Note | **Whole Rest** | **Half Note** | **Half Rest** | **Quarter Notes** | **Quarter Rests** | **Eighth Notes (beams or flags)** | **Eighth Rests**

Dots add half the original length
Quarter note = 2 eighth notes
Dotted quarter = 3 eighth notes

Ties connect two notes, making the starting note last through the length of the second

Staccato dots make notes short

Legato lines make 'em long and connected

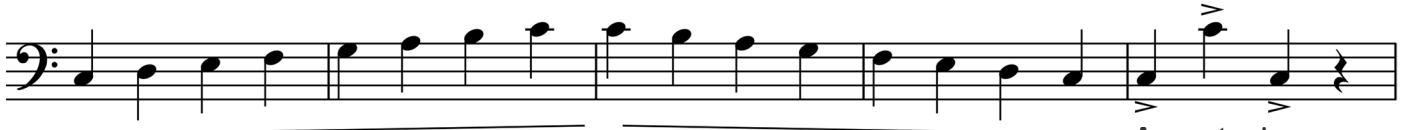


1 + 2 + 3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 + 4 +

Dynamics

pp ***p*** ***mp*** ***mf*** ***f*** ***ff***

quiet → **loud**



crescendo: gradually get louder

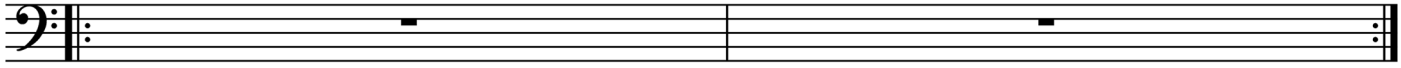
decrescendo: gradually get softer

Accent: give that note extra emphasis

Navigation

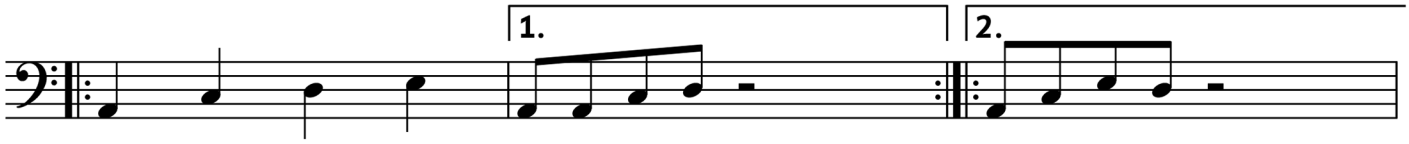
Starting repeat

End repeat
tells you to go back to the starting repeat



The 1st ending tells you to read through it one time

but then skip past it to the 2nd ending on repeat



BASS BUZZ